artisans.[10] As the Company wielded greater power, cotton, textile trading and tax farming—the practice of the government outsourcing revenue collection—also attracted Parsi enterprise in the 18th century. Weaving and liquor distillation were other sectors of Parsi interest.[11] All these activities entailed Parsi migration from the Navsari–Surat region to Bombay. Later, their descendants would spur the industrial world of cotton mills in the late 19th century.

In between these two epochs, the opium trade with China ‘played a major role in making wealthy merchants out of Parsis’.[12] The Readymoneys, a Parsi family, would be the first to settle in China, but there were hundreds of Parsi traders who would ply between Bombay and Canton by the middle of the 19th century. The phenomenal rise of Jamsetjee Jejeebhoy (1783–1859), the trading magnate, occurred due to a chance encounter with William Jardine on a ship and the subsequent collaboration with Jardine Matheson Company, the largest company involved in the opium trade. He would defray much of this opium-driven wealth during his lifetime by pioneering secular philanthropy towards public institutions. In contrast to Jardine Matheson, a firm that continues to dominate the corporate world of Hong Kong and South East Asia, Jejeebhoy’s business does not have a strong legacy, but his philanthropic contributions still dot the city of Mumbai with several institutions bearing his name, best known by his initials ‘J.J.’

The opium and cotton trade was initially important for the Tata family too, but by the end of the 19th century J.N. Tata (1839–1904) was focussed on cotton mills and his dream project—a state-of-the-art steel plant.[13] He would not live to see the steel plant in action in 1911, but two months after his death, his nephew, J.R.D. Tata (1904–93) was born, who grew up to oversee the dramatic expansion of the Tata Group in the 20th century. J.R.D. Tata’s migratory links included Paris, the city he was born in to his French mother, as well as his pioneering contributions to India’s air passenger service that finally became Air India.

At the turn of the 20th century, there were over 80,000 Parsis in British India, more than half of them in the city of Bombay, 6000 in Surat and 2000